

Seeing Through Deception: Advanced Information Literacy

GRADES 6-8

35 MINUTES

LIBRARY

Students develop sophisticated source evaluation skills by connecting the history of visual deception—from spirit photography to deepfakes—to contemporary information literacy challenges.

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Students will trace the evolution of visual misinformation from 1860s spirit photography to modern deepfakes, master the SIFT method for lateral reading and source verification, and apply these skills to evaluate real-world examples.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

AASL I.B.1: Using evidence to investigate questions. **AASL I.D.2:** Evaluating information for accuracy, validity, context.

CCSS.ELA-LITERACY.RI.7.8: Trace and evaluate the argument and specific claims in a text.

MATERIALS NEEDED

- Spirit photography examples from Mini Museum • Modern manipulated images • Brief deepfake video clip
- SIFT method poster/handout • Sample sources for lateral reading practice
- **Mini Museum Perception Lab:** minimuseumproject.com/exhibitions/seeing-is-deceiving/illusions

RECOMMENDED RESOURCES

True or False? A CIA Analyst's Guide

by Cindy L. Otis

Verified: How to Think Straight

by Caulfield & Wineburg

LESSON PLAN

Hook: A 160-Year Timeline of Deception (5 minutes)

Display timeline: Spirit Photography (1860s) → Photo Retouching (1900s) → Photoshop (1990s) → Deepfakes (2010s-present).

"Every generation faces a new form of visual deception—and every generation thinks THEY can spot the fakes. In the 1860s, thousands paid money for photographs of ghosts they believed were real. They weren't stupid—they were trusting. Photography was new technology, and they didn't know it could be manipulated. WE are in exactly the same position today with AI-generated content."

The SIFT Method: Professional Verification (10 minutes)

Introduce the SIFT method, developed by digital literacy expert Mike Caulfield:

S STOP — Before you share, react, or use the information—pause. Don't let emotion drive action.

I INVESTIGATE the Source — What do you know about this website, author, or organization? Take 30 seconds to find out WHO is behind the content.

F FIND Better Coverage — Can you find the same claim elsewhere? Check if reputable sources cover this story.

T TRACE to the Original — Where did this information ACTUALLY come from? Follow the chain to the primary source.

Lesson Plan (continued)

"This is what professional fact-checkers do. The key insight is LATERAL READING—instead of reading deeply on a suspicious site, you leave it immediately and search for information ABOUT that source."

Mini Museum Connection: The Psychology of Belief (5 minutes)

Reference the exhibition. William Mumler was put on trial for fraud in 1869 but acquitted—not because innocent, but because prosecution couldn't prove HOW he faked photos.

Key questions: Why were grieving families especially vulnerable? (Emotional state, motivated reasoning) How does this connect to modern misinformation? (We believe what we WANT to believe) What would have helped Victorians verify? (Consulting experts, comparing work—lateral reading)

Activity: SIFT in Action (12 minutes)

Present 3-4 examples of varying reliability:

- A viral social media post claiming a celebrity said something shocking (no source link)
- A Wikipedia article on a scientific topic
- A news story from an unfamiliar website
- A spirit photograph from 1870 (historical application)

For each: S (What's your emotional reaction?), I (What can you find about this source?), F (Who else covers this?), T (Can you trace to primary source?)

Closing: Your Responsibility (3 minutes)

"You are growing up in the first generation where anyone can create convincing fake video and audio. These skills work across ALL media. Lateral reading, source checking, and emotional awareness will never become obsolete."

Mini Museum Connection

Option 1 — Visit: The exhibition provides a perfect case study for visual deception exploiting psychological vulnerabilities. Spirit photography targeted grief; deepfakes target political division.

Option 2 — Virtual: Explore at minimuseumproject.com/exhibitions/seeing-is-deceiving

ASSESSMENT

Application: Can students correctly apply all four SIFT steps to a novel source?

Analysis: Can students explain WHY lateral reading works better than reading deeply on a suspicious site?

Exit ticket: "Explain the connection between spirit photography and modern misinformation."

DIFFERENTIATED STUDENT HANDOUTS

- **Green:** SIFT reference guide with scaffolded source evaluation
- **Yellow:** Independent SIFT analysis of multiple sources with explanation
- **Red:** Research project on deepfakes; create verification guide for peers